beauties' from it.[21] Akbar discovered the loss, and had the women found and returned. He wasn't allowed to investigate their disappearance, however. A 'severed head makes no sound', as Abul Fazl writes: Maham Anaka had them both killed before they could be questioned.

Akbar didn't ask her what happened. Perhaps he didn't want to know; he was still behind that veil of his, he 'had not yet revealed himself'.[22] Instead, he continued his journey back home. On the way, he fought and killed a lioness – less daunting a creature, it appears, than Akbar's formidable nurse.

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The sixth year of Akbar's reign abounds with examples of his growing, sometimes reckless courage. Five years ago, it was a nilgai Akbar had killed on the side of the road; now, a lioness with five cubs stood in his way. Akbar approached her on foot, and killed her with one blow. It was in this year, too, that Abul Fazl reveals another of Akbar's dangerous pleasures: he liked venturing into public, incognito. One night, in Agra, he was wandering through a great crowd, gathered for an *urs*, when he was recognized. Who knows what might have happened next if Akbar hadn't thought on his feet. He squinted and contorted his features, edging his way, thus disguised, from the crowd back to the fort.

It wasn't, however, that Akbar was shy of appearing in public as himself. Once, famously, he rode an enraged elephant through Agra, chasing its rival across a pontoon bridge – built on boats that sank in and out of the water under the weight of the 'two mountain forms', while Akbar's retainers threw themselves into the river, swimming alongside their apparently deranged padishah.

Among those watching in panic was Akbar's ataka, Shamsuddin. In another reckless act that year, Akbar had decided to accept his foster father's petition for a promotion, called him to Agra and made him vakil, or deputy, stripping the title from Munim Khan, and also, more importantly, from Maham Anaka, 'who regarded herself as the [vakil]'.[23] Six months had passed since the whole Adham Khan affair, but some suspicion of him and his mother may have lodged itself in Akbar's head. Maham was 'displeased at this', writes Abul Fazl – Munim Khan was still khan-khanan, at least; what was Maham supposed to do with herself and her abundant